Formal structures: inversion, emphasis and it is essential that

Understand it

Formal structures add range and emphasis. Use them sparingly: one or two in an essay is enough. Overusing them sounds unnatural.

Inversion means putting the auxiliary verb before the subject after a negative or limiting word at the start of a sentence.

The rules

- Negative adverbs at the start need inversion (auxiliary before subject): Never has the world been so connected. Rarely do people read long articles.
- Not only ... but also: Not only does it save money, but it also protects nature.
- Cleft sentences for emphasis: It is education that shapes a society. What worries me is the cost.
- Subjunctive after essential / vital / important that: It is essential that every child have access to books. (base verb, no -s)

All the words and forms you need

Inversion after negatives	Never · Rarely · Seldom · Hardly ever · Not only · Not until · Under no circumstances · Little · Only then
Cleft (emphasis)	It is ... that ... · What ... is ... · The reason why ... is ...
Formal 'should' / subjunctive	It is essential / vital / crucial / important that + base verb
Formal linking	Consequently · Furthermore · Moreover · Thus · Hence
Impersonal	It is widely believed that · It could be argued that · It is often said that

Where you use it

Writing: Use one or two of these in an essay, not more. They show range at band 7.

Speaking: What I find interesting is ...; It is the weather that I hate most.

Reading: Inversion looks strange but means the same as a normal sentence.

More examples

- Not only does exercise improve health, but it also reduces stress.
- Rarely do young people read printed newspapers.
- It is the government that must take the lead.

- What concerns me most is the cost of housing.
- It is essential that every child have access to education.
- It could be argued that tourism does more harm than good.

Common mistakes

Wrong	Right
✗ Never I have seen such a thing.	✓ Never have I seen such a thing.
✗ Not only it is cheap, but also fast.	✓ Not only is it cheap, but it is also fast.
✗ It is vital that he arrives early.	✓ It is vital that he arrive early. (formal)

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. What worries you most about the future? (start with What worries me most is ...)
2. What is the main reason people learn English?
3. What is it that makes a city a good place to live?
4. Is it true that people read less than before?
5. What is essential for a happy life?

Writing practice

Rewrite with inversion: People rarely think about where their food comes from. / Exercise saves money and it improves mood.

Practice

1. Rewrite with Rarely: People walk to work.

2. Rewrite with Not only: It is cheap. It is also safe.

3. Rewrite with It is ... that: Pollution causes the problem.

4. Complete: It is essential that the law ___ (apply) to all.

5. Correct: Seldom we see such honesty.

6. Rewrite with What: I need more time.

Answers

1. Rarely do people walk to work.
2. Not only is it cheap, but it is also safe.
3. It is pollution that causes the problem.
4. apply
5. Seldom do we see such honesty.
6. What I need is more time.